Tides of Loyalty

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Tides of Loyalty

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Summary

> Phainon stared at him for a long moment, his frustration giving way to something darker. His hands were shaking, and there was a tremble in his voice when he spoke again. “Who did this to you?” His words were firm, no longer a question but an imperative. “Who the hell did this?”

Or in which Mydei goes on a solo mission, gets mortally wounded a few times, and Phainon has to clean up the mess—while trying not to lose his mind in the process.

Notes

Sorry abt not uploading anything for a few days, I had schoolwork😭 I’m gonna be a bit busier for a few months but I hope you guys can be patient for a bit❤❤

Ngl I remembered that I wrote a who did this to u Mydei fanfic before and wanted to do a Phainon one too, so voila, here’s my second attempt at this.

Enjoy <333

See the end of the work for more notes

The battlefield was chaos.

Smoke curled in the air, thick with the stench of blood and scorched metal. Bodies lay broken in the dirt—Titankin corpses, their monstrous forms twisted in death, black ichor pooling beneath them. Mydei stood among them, breath steady, shoulders squared, his gauntlets slick with golden and black blood alike.

He had fought through worse.

The metal plating of his gauntlets hummed faintly, pulsing with the energy left behind from every strike. Dents marred the surface, scratches carving their way through the once-smooth steel, but they still held strong. Good. Because this fight wasn’t over yet.

A low growl rumbled through the battlefield as the remaining Titankin circled him. Their massive bodies moved with a predatory patience, shifting their weight as they studied him. They weren’t mindless. Not this time.

That was the problem.

One lunged first.

Mydei ducked low, shifting his stance just in time to avoid the sweeping claws. His gauntlet-clad fist shot upward, catching the beast beneath the jaw with a sharp crack. The force sent it staggering back, but another was already coming from behind.

He twisted, raising his arm as claws scraped against metal, sending sparks flying. He didn’t let it push him back. Instead, he used the momentum, hooking his leg around its knee, slamming his fist into its gut, then driving his elbow down into the back of its neck. The creature collapsed with a choked snarl, but Mydei was already moving again.

Strike. Dodge. Counter.

His breath came steady. His muscles burned.

Still manageable.

Until he heard it.

The scuff of hurried footsteps.

His gaze flicked to the side. Just for a second.

The civilian.

He was running.

Panic twisted in his movements, his head darting frantically as he stumbled through the wreckage. He wasn't looking where he was going, only away from the fight, away from the danger.

Mydei felt his stomach twist.

He had told him to stay put. Not to move. Not to make himself a target.

And then he saw it.

One of the Titankin broke away from the fight, its massive form shifting toward the noise. Its head lifted, nostrils flaring as it caught the scent of easier prey.

It wasn't looking at Mydei anymore.

It had found something better.

His chest went cold.

He moved without thinking.

One second, he was mid-dodge, twisting past another attack. The next, he was sprinting across the battlefield, pushing past his own injuries, his own exhaustion.

He wasn't fast enough.

The moment the beast lunged, Mydei did the only thing he could.

He threw himself in the way.

The impact was instant.

Pain lanced through his chest as something sharp drove straight through his ribs. His vision blurred at the edges, body locking up as his own momentum carried him forward. The air punched from his lungs.

Then another strike. And another.

His knees buckled, the world tilting as his body gave out beneath him. He hit the ground hard, metal scraping against stone, the scent of blood thick in the air.

His own blood.

Golden ichor spilled from the wounds, his body already trying to heal, but the damage was deep. Too much, too fast. His limbs refused to move the way they should.

He tried to push himself up. A boot pressed down against his shoulder, pinning him where he lay.

The Strife follower, at least the more sane one of it had the ability to speak properly, loomed above him, head tilting slightly as he regarded Mydei's broken form. His expression was almost bored.

"You took your time falling."

Mydei bared his teeth, but his body wouldn't cooperate. His vision flickered. His fingers twitched uselessly against the dirt.

Dying never got easier.

And it sure as hell never hurt less.

Mydei’s world flickered again, just for a second, as the sharp sting of death clawed its way back. He felt the weight of the Titankin’s claws tearing into his flesh, dragging him down. His vision blurred as darkness crept in at the edges, but he wasn’t done yet.

He couldn’t be.

With a strained grunt, he forced his body to move, muscles screaming in protest. His gauntlets slammed into the creature’s face with all the force he could muster, sending it stumbling back. He didn’t wait for it to recover.

He surged forward, grabbing another by the throat, his fist a hammer of raw power as he crushed its windpipe. The thing flailed, choking and clawing at his arm, but Mydei kept his grip tight, refusing to let go. He didn’t care about the blood soaking into his clothing, the broken ribs, or the twisted mess of his own body.

As long as he could still move, he would keep fighting.

He kicked another away, the force of the blow knocking it off-balance long enough for him to roll to his feet, blood dripping from his mouth as his body struggled to repair itself.

But it didn’t matter. They were too many.

The follower of Strife if he could would have a smirk on his face, eyes coldas he watched the struggle. He raised a hand, beckoning the other creatures forward. Mydei could barely see straight anymore, his vision flickering in and out. It felt like his body was being held together with little more than threads of willpower.

Then, just as he thought he had a chance—

Another strike.

This time, it was a dagger, driven straight through his side. The pain was instant, a wave of cold washing over him as he gasped for air. His body

froze, locking up as his gauntlet hand trembled. His vision darkened, then snapped back, but this time it was too much.

He felt the ground shift beneath him, and then he was falling.

His breath caught in his throat as his limbs refused to move, his muscles no longer responding to his command. A final strike—a slash to the throat—ripped through his skin, and the world around him went black.

-

He came back again.

This time, he couldn’t make sense of where he was. The darkness around him was suffocating, and the air was thick with the smell of blood. His eyes snapped open, but everything was a blur.

He tried to move, but his limbs wouldn’t cooperate. His chest heaved as he fought for control, his breath ragged and desperate. His gauntlets—his only source of strength—were slipping from his grasp, the weight of his injuries pushing him to the brink.

He couldn’t stop it.

He couldn’t escape.

It was like the battle was happening in slow motion. Each death felt like an eternity, stretching on and on as he kept dying over and over. He lost track of how many times it had happened, how many times his body had been ripped apart, only to be forced back into the fight.

Then he heard it again, that cold, mocking voice.

“Even the immortals fall.”

Mydei wanted to laugh.

Because no.

No, he wasn’t falling.

He was just waiting to get back up.

-

Each time he was brought back, the pain was unbearable. His muscles burned, his body screaming in protest as it healed, but it never felt fast enough. The strikes were too much, too fast, and his body was too torn apart to recover. But he didn’t care.

He would keep fighting.

He would keep moving.

One of the Titankin lunged at him from the side, slashing across his chest. He staggered back, but his gauntlet flashed out, striking its jaw with a bone-crushing impact. The beast’s head snapped back, but before Mydei could push forward, another creature rushed in. This time, it was too fast.

It dug its claws into his stomach, lifting him off his feet before slamming him into the ground with a sickening crunch.

Mydei couldn’t fight it.

He couldn’t breathe.

His vision darkened once more, and this time, the numbness took over completely.

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He came back again.

The moment he opened his eyes, his body screamed at him to move. To fight. But he could barely feel his hands. His gauntlets were heavy, as if the weight of the battle had shattered them. Blood pooled beneath him, the ground slick with it, and the air tasted of iron.

The follower of Strife was still standing over him, calm and indifferent. His gaze flicked to Mydei's broken form, then to the dying creatures around them.

"Still waiting, are we?" the follower said, his voice devoid of anything but detached amusement.

Mydei's gaze flicked to the idiot who had started all of this—who had run, who had gotten him into this mess.

A wave of anger surged through him, something that burned hotter than any pain.

He hadn't given up.

Not yet.

Not ever.

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It had started simply enough.

A mission.

Nothing Mydei hadn't done before. He didn't need anyone's help for this one. Not even Phainon.

He hadn't told anyone, aside from Algaea—just the bare essentials, a quick mention of his plans, because, well, he trusted her judgment. She hadn't questioned it.

Everyone else?

They didn't need to know.

Solo missions weren't unusual for Mydei. He had a reputation for handling them with ease, walking away without so much as a scratch. Immortal, after all.

The Titankin were becoming more erratic, pushing toward the outer settlements, and there were whispers of Strife's followers stirring trouble in the shadows.

The details weren't clear, but Mydei didn't care about that. The job was simple: eliminate the Titankin, find out what they were up to, and leave the mess behind for someone else to clean up.

No need to bother Phainon or anyone else with it. They had bigger problems, after all.

But there was always something.

The Titankin were worse than he'd anticipated, and when the strife follower showed up, Mydei realized too late that he might've underestimated the situation.

And then, there was the civilian.

That damn fool.

He'd told him to stay put, but the idiot had run.

Mydei had no choice but to make sure the runaway wasn't followed. It was a mess, and now… now he was paying the price.

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The world was closing in around him. Mydei could feel the weight of his own blood, thick and hot, seeping from the gaping wound in his chest. It poured from him in torrents, mixing with the dirt beneath him. Every heartbeat sent another surge of crimson, his lungs filling with the sickening metallic taste as it flooded his airway.

His vision was blurry, but he could still see the shadow of the follower of Strife standing above him, blade still dripping with his blood. It felt like hours had passed, though it could have been mere minutes. His body twitched with the last spasms of life, the pain far too overwhelming to ignore, but still, something deep inside him kept him from letting go.

He’d survived worse. He always did.

But now, with the blood pouring into his lungs, choking him, the edge of death felt… different. More real. The ache in his chest was unbearable. His body was screaming, every inch of him torn and broken. He wanted to gasp for air, but the more he tried, the worse it got. His limbs were useless, crushed beneath him, and his body refused to do anything except lie there, trembling.

He had failed.

But in the corner of his fading vision, a flash of steel caught his eye.

A sword—familiar. The gleam of it was like a beacon in his haze. His heart skipped in his chest as he saw it, recognizing it instantly. There was only one person who wielded a blade like that.

Phainon.

He’d come.

The sound of the sword cutting through air was like a divine wind, a sudden gust of death that swept the follower of Strife off his feet. Mydei couldn’t tell what happened next—the world was fading too quickly, his head too heavy, but he knew Phainon had arrived. The rest was a blur of movement, the way Phainon dispatched the remaining enemies in brutal, efficient silence. It was like watching a storm tear through the last remnants of a broken world. There was no hesitation. Just death.

And then—nothing.

The battlefield was still, only the echoes of what had been left in the wake of Phainon’s fury. Mydei was alone again, but not for long. He could hear the familiar footfalls, the clinking of armor, and the sound of Phainon’s breathing—a deep, frantic rhythm as he approached.

At first, all Mydei could do was lie there, feeling the pull of darkness drawing him in like a riptide. But the sound of Phainon’s voice cut through

the haze, the relief in his tone barely masking the fear.

“Mydei?” The word came out rough, like it hurt just to speak it. The next thing Mydei felt was the sharp sting of hands lifting him, pulling him, but it was almost too much. He could barely lift his head. The grip was firm, but there was something else in Phainon’s touch—something desperate, trembling.

Phainon’s eyes fell on him, and the anger in his gaze quickly morphed into horror. His face drained of color, his expression faltering as he took in Mydei’s state. For a long second, he didn’t say anything. He simply stared, frozen, as if trying to reconcile the sight of Mydei’s broken form with the man he’d known.

Mydei, gasping for air, met his eyes, barely able to keep his own open. The world was spinning, and the pain was almost too much to bear. But Phainon wasn’t angry anymore. He looked… terrified. The kind of fear that made Mydei’s gut twist.

Phainon’s hand trembled as he reached out, brushing his fingers against Mydei’s face, almost as if unsure he was real. His voice cracked when he spoke.

“Mydei… what happened?” The question was weak, barely a whisper, as if Phainon feared hearing the answer.

Mydei didn’t answer immediately. His mind was too hazy, the blood filling his lungs, drowning him. He felt himself slipping away again, and despite everything, he couldn’t find it in him to care. It had been a hell of a fight. It was enough.

But then Phainon’s grip tightened on his arm, his voice growing more desperate, more frantic.

“You’ll be fine. I’ll—” Phainon’s words faltered as his eyes darted around, panic seizing him, and for a brief moment, it looked like he didn’t know what to do.

He was shaking now, more than Mydei had ever seen before. The usual calm, steady confidence was gone. In its place, there was only fear. Phainon was scared—*scared for him.*

“Don’t you dare…” Phainon muttered, his voice trembling with raw emotion. His gaze fell to Mydei’s chest, the gaping wound still pumping blood with every weak heartbeat.

Mydei wanted to laugh, but the only sound that came out was a wet, desperate cough. The blood continued to pour, thick and suffocating.

“Just… need a minute,” Mydei rasped, his voice barely audible. He could feel his body shaking, the darkness pressing in, but he didn’t want to say goodbye—not like this. Not when Phainon was here.

Phainon didn’t seem to hear him. He kept talking, too fast, too desperately, but his words were nothing but a blur to Mydei. All Mydei could focus on was the way Phainon’s hand trembled, hovering over him like he didn’t know whether to touch him or not. The worry in his eyes was too much to bear. Mydei wanted to say something to ease the pain, to tell him it was going to be okay, but the words wouldn’t come.

“I’ll get you back,” Phainon promised, though there was a crack in his voice that shattered Mydei’s resolve. Phainon’s hand slid down to Mydei’s shoulder, but it was stiff, unsure. “I’ll get you to safety, I swear.”

But Mydei couldn’t bring himself to answer, his eyes falling closed as the world around him slipped into the darkness once again. The sound of Phainon’s frantic breath was the last thing he heard.

The seconds felt like hours, each one slipping by too slowly, a cruel reminder of how close Mydei had come to staying in the darkness. His body trembled, and the taste of blood still clung to his mouth, thick and metallic. He could feel the world pressing in around him, the weight of the injuries and the exhaustion nearly suffocating him.

And then, after what felt like an eternity, something shifted.

His lungs burned as he gasped for air, blood erupting from his throat in ragged coughs. His eyes shot open, and the world around him came back into focus, though everything still felt distant, as if he were watching it from far away. His body jolted with the force of another cough, blood spilling from his lips and staining the dirt beneath him.

He barely had time to process the feeling of being alive again before he pushed himself shakily to his hands and knees, his gauntlets scraping against the rough ground. His chest ached, his body protesting every movement, but still, he dragged himself to his feet, stumbling slightly as he looked around.

Phainon was still there, standing nearby, his posture tense, his breathing sharp and uneven. The usual warmth and ease in his demeanor were gone, replaced by a sharp, anxious edge. His hands were clenched into fists at his sides, his jaw tight as he struggled to keep his composure. But even with all the effort, the trembling in his fingers was unmistakable.

“Damn it, Mydei…” Phainon’s voice cracked as he stepped closer, his eyes wild with a mix of anger and fear. He was trying, desperately trying, to hide the panic that was written all over his face, but it was there, raw and exposed.

Mydei shook his head, still catching his breath, his chest tight as he fought to keep the blood from pouring back into his lungs. “I’m fine,” he rasped, but it sounded weak, even to him. He glanced over at Phainon, seeing the way his shoulders were stiff, his lips pressed together in an effort to control himself. “You didn’t need to worry.”

Phainon’s eyes narrowed, though, his gaze piercing as he stepped forward, his voice low and harsh. “What were you thinking?” The words came out like a snapped command, his frustration and fear finally breaking free. “*What the hell were you thinking?!*”

Mydei swallowed hard, his head still swimming with the aftereffects of the blood loss and the multiple experience. He met Phainon’s gaze, his own eyes glazed and unfocused, but something in him resisted answering right

away. The words were there, somewhere in his mind, but they felt distant, as if they weren't quite his own.

"I had to protect the civilians," Mydei muttered, though it came out weaker than he intended. His eyes dropped briefly, before returning to Phainon's face, his gaze softer. "You don't need to worry. I'm fine."

Phainon's mouth twisted in disbelief, frustration bubbling up to the surface again. His voice cut through the air like a whip, harsh and edged with anger. "Do you think this is a joke, Mydei?" His tone was sharp, venomous. "You could've died! You don't get to act like this is just another damn mission!"

Mydei winced, a lump forming in his throat at the sight of Phainon's eyes, filled with an emotion he wasn't used to seeing—raw, genuine fear. He opened his mouth to speak, to brush it off like always, but something in Phainon's stare stopped him.

Phainon stared at him for a long moment, his frustration giving way to something darker. His hands were shaking, and there was a tremble in his voice when he spoke again. "Who did this to you?" His words were firm, no longer a question but an imperative. "Who the hell did this?"

Mydei's heart skipped a beat. The intensity in Phainon's gaze made his chest tighten. He swallowed again, but this time, the words didn't come so easily. He'd been cornered by a follower of Strife and had been willing to die to protect someone who ran when told to stay. But admitting that, to Phainon, seemed impossible.

"I—" Mydei stopped himself. His throat felt tight. He shook his head, as though trying to shake off the reality of it all. "There was a runaway," he muttered, voice barely above a whisper. His eyes dropped to the ground, then back up to Phainon's. "Someone ran when I told them not to. I had to cover for them before they got hit."

Phainon's grip on Mydei's arm tightened as he processed the words, but then, without warning, it softened. He exhaled sharply, his features softening as the weight of it all seemed to settle on him. "Damn it,

Mydei…” He didn’t say anything for a long moment, his hand dropping from Mydei’s arm as he took a step back.

“Go ahead with the others,” Phainon said, his voice softer now, though still filled with an underlying edge. “I’ll find him. You’re in no condition to be chasing anyone right now.”

Mydei hesitated for a moment, but then nodded, feeling the sharp pull of exhaustion weigh down on him. His body was barely functional, but there was no time to rest. “Fine,” he muttered. “But don’t leave him out there too long. We need him alive.”

Phainon didn’t reply right away, his eyes watching Mydei closely as he took a step back. His expression was unreadable, a strange mixture of relief and something darker Mydei couldn’t quite place. “Go,” Phainon repeated. “I’ll take care of the rest.”

Mydei took one last lingering look at Phainon, his heart heavy as the weight of everything pressed down on him. The blood on his hands—both his own and the others’—felt suffocating, as if he were still drowning in it. He knew he should be getting out of there, but a part of him wanted to stay with Phainon, to let the other man help him get through it. But there was no time for that.

“I’ll be fine,” Mydei muttered, the words feeling weak even to his own ears. “Just… stay safe.”

Phainon didn’t respond immediately, but his eyes followed Mydei’s every move, watching the way his shoulders sagged with exhaustion, the way his steps wavered with every motion. But still, there was nothing but silence.

Mydei hesitated one last time, then turned away, feeling the eyes of the world on his back as he walked toward the others. His pace was slow, but he forced himself forward. He didn’t want to admit it, but Phainon’s worry was written all over him, and it was hard to ignore.

As he took a few more steps, his own body felt like it was rejecting the idea of moving, like every part of him was begging for rest. But there was no

time to think of that now.

Phainon stood there for a long moment, watching Mydei leave with the others, his eyes following him until he was swallowed by the shadows. The air was thick, heavy with the weight of everything that had just happened. His jaw clenched, and his fists tightened at his sides as the anger began to boil within him, slowly rising like a tide.

Damn him.

He had barely been able to stop himself from storming after Mydei, grabbing him and shaking him until he got his head on straight. But that wasn't it. That wasn't why he was angry. Phainon's anger wasn't aimed at Mydei—it never was. It was always at the situations, the people, the things that put Mydei in danger, that made him hurt himself like this.

It was the damn runaway. The idiot who had gotten scared and bolted when they needed him the most. It was that coward that had pushed Mydei to the edge, made him take that fatal risk to protect someone who didn't even have the decency to stay put.

Phainon's breathing grew heavier, and the weight of the situation settled into his chest, making his heart ache in a way he couldn't put into words. He wanted to scream. To shout, to lash out at the entire world for making Mydei feel like he had to do this on his own.

But that wouldn't do any good.

Mydei was already gone, walking away from everything without so much as a word. Phainon's hands dropped to his sides, the anger burning in his chest, but beneath that, there was something deeper, something colder, that twisted in his gut.

It wasn't just anger.

It was fear.

The idea that Mydei might leave without saying goodbye, without knowing just how much Phainon cared, struck a chord deep in his heart. He hated it. He hated how easily Mydei pushed those feelings aside, how he kept charging forward without ever considering the consequences for himself—or for Phainon.

He wanted to scream, to drag Mydei back, to demand he think of something other than the mission, other than the fight. He wanted to force Mydei to feel—to realize just how much Phainon needed him to stay alive. But that wasn't the way it worked, was it?

Mydei was always like this. Always so damn stubborn.

And Phainon? He was helpless.

Phainon moved through the woods with an easy grace, each step deliberate and controlled. The quiet rustle of the leaves barely registered to him anymore, his thoughts focused entirely on the task at hand. There was no more time for anger, but the frustration was palpable, and his irritation had taken on a sharper edge since Mydei's reckless stunt.

Every enemy that appeared in his path was dispatched with little effort, his sword a blur of precision and speed. Each Titan Kin he killed seemed to fuel the next step toward his goal. But it wasn't until he found the cave that his pace slowed. There, the runaway was supposed to be—hiding, likely terrified for his life.

Instead, Phainon found the man sitting lazily against a rock at the entrance to the cave. The night air hung heavy, but the runaway looked utterly at ease, an absurd contrast to the situation. His arms were draped across his knees, eyes half-lidded with relaxation. The offerings scattered before him—broken weapons, scraps of food, things clearly meant to appease the Titan Kin—didn't escape Phainon's notice. The man had been making deals with the enemy.

The Titankin sat in a loose circle, watching the man, and to Phainon's growing anger, the runaway didn't seem alarmed. He wasn't hiding; he

wasn’t even afraid. He was lounging, like a king amongst creatures he should have been terrified of.

Phainon’s jaw tightened. That was it. The trust they had shown him, the protection they had offered, all for nothing. His eyes flickered to the Titankin, assessing them, calculating. None of them seemed to notice him yet, and he didn’t plan on letting them.

He stepped forward.

The runaway’s head snapped up, his eyes locking onto the tall figure emerging from the shadows. His expression shifted from surprise to wide-eyed admiration as recognition hit.

“Phainon?” the runaway gasped, his voice full of awe. “The Deliverer of Okhema! I can’t believe it’s you!”

Phainon’s face remained as neutral as possible, though a tight smile formed, not quite reaching his eyes. It didn’t matter if the man knew who he was; all that mattered was what he had done.

“Didn’t expect a hero like you to show up here,” the runaway continued, completely oblivious to the tension in Phainon’s posture. He stood, dusting himself off and stepping forward, eyes still filled with admiration. “I… I never got the chance to thank you for—”

Phainon’s smile froze. He glanced around, noticing something move just behind the runaway. His instincts flared.

The Titankin had managed to sneak up behind him. Phainon’s expression didn’t change, but his body tensed, the sword in his hand resting at his side. He let the man fawn over him a little longer, the words a constant drone in his ear, until the Titan Kin was almost in place.

Then he struck.

In one fluid motion, Phainon closed the distance between them. With a savage shove, he slammed the Titankin into the cave wall so hard that the

creature’s face collapsed inward on impact. The sound of cracking stone echoed in the confined space, followed by the horrible, splintering noise of the creature’s skull. The Titan Kin’s body slumped to the floor with a final, sickening thud, leaving a massive indent in the stone wall where its face had met it.

The runaway gasped, his eyes wide with fear for the first time since Phainon had arrived.

Phainon turned to face him, his face still the picture of calm, though his eyes had hardened, cold and unwavering. His expression remained stoic, but his voice had an edge to it now, sharp enough to cut through the tension that clung to the cave.

“Didn’t expect you to be so comfortable around them,” Phainon said, his voice unnervingly cheerful, but the fire behind it was unmistakable. “Especially when your life was just hanging in the balance.”

The runaway looked horrified now, a mixture of guilt and fear swirling in his eyes. He’d clearly realized the mistake he had made, but it was too late. The damage was done.

“P-Phainon,” the runaway stammered, taking a step back as if trying to distance himself from the Deliverer. “I—I didn’t know they’d—”

Phainon’s eyes narrowed, and the gentle facade he usually wore completely disappeared. His smile faded, replaced with a quiet, menacing stillness. “You didn’t know? Well, you’re sure as hell going to learn now, aren’t you?”

The runaway swallowed hard, taking another step back. Phainon took a long moment to gaze at him, the anger still simmering just beneath the surface, before he finally let out a slow, controlled breath.

“Get up,” he said coldly. “You’re coming with me.”

The runaway hesitated but slowly began to rise to his feet, fear clearly written across his face. His admiration for Phainon was long gone, replaced

by the overwhelming terror of having seen what the man was capable of. For the first time, he wasn't in awe—he was scared.

"Now," Phainon continued, his tone still icy, "we're going to walk out of this cave. You're going to follow me, and you're going to pray that Mydei doesn't hear about this. Because if he does, I'll make sure you regret it."

Phainon's grip on Ermis' arm was firm, dragging him through the darkened forest without a word. The trees whispered around them, the occasional rustle of movement in the underbrush putting the runaway on edge.

Ermis was fidgeting, shifting uncomfortably, but Phainon didn't bother looking at him. He knew the type. Guilt-ridden, anxious, searching for an excuse—none of which Phainon had the patience for.

They hadn't made it far before Ermis tensed. His breathing shifted, his stance subtly adjusting as if preparing to bolt.

Phainon sighed. "Don't."

Ermis hesitated. "I wasn't—"

Phainon finally glanced at him, expression unreadable. "Don't insult my intelligence."

That shut him up. At least, for a while.

They continued, the campfires in the distance growing closer, but the forest wasn't empty. Phainon sensed them before they revealed themselves, the faint shift in the air, the unnatural stillness.

Titankin again. This place was infested with them.

Phainon stopped walking, pushing Ermis slightly behind him. "Stay."

Ermis opened his mouth—probably to argue, to claim he didn't need protection—but he shut it when he saw the way Phainon's fingers curled around his sword.

The creatures moved first, lunging from the shadows.

Phainon was faster.

His blade carved through the first enemies chest before it could reach them, severing its core with one clean strike. The second tried to flank him, but he pivoted, ducking beneath its heavy swing before driving his sword through its skull. It crumbled to dust before it even hit the ground.

He barely even broke a sweat.

But when he turned back to Ermis, the man was gone.

Phainon’s expression didn’t change, but something in his posture shifted. He closed his eyes for a beat, inhaled through his nose, then exhaled.

Then he moved.

It didn’t take long to find him. Ermis wasn’t exactly trained in stealth, and his hurried footsteps through the underbrush were loud enough to track without much effort.

Phainon caught up within moments, stepping in front of him so suddenly that Ermis barely had time to react before the cold press of a blade met his throat.

Sharp, unwavering, just enough pressure to draw the faintest bead of blood.

Ermis froze, eyes wide, chest rising and falling rapidly.

Phainon tilted his head slightly, his grip steady, his voice almost bored but edged with unmistakable irritation.

“You wanna try again?”

Ermis swallowed hard, throat bobbing against the blade. “I—”

“Because I don’t mind running you back down.” Phainon’s voice was even, but the unspoken threat lingered. He didn’t need to elaborate.

Ermis' hands trembled at his sides, his escape attempt clearly dead in the water.

Phainon held his gaze for another long moment before finally lowering his sword. He exhaled, the tension in his shoulders shifting from sharp to resigned. "Smart choice."

Without another word, he grabbed Ermis by the arm again, none too gently, and resumed their path toward the camp.

This time, Ermis didn't try to run.

Phainon had returned with Ermis at his side, the weight of the earlier confrontation still pressing on his mind. He kept his pace steady, though his thoughts churned, the image of Mydei's bloodied form still vivid in his mind. He had been ready to tear through anything that threatened him, and now that they were heading back, a strange sense of unease lingered. The last thing Phainon needed was for someone like Ermis to make a rash mistake again, to put Mydei in harm's way.

As they approached the camp, Phainon's eyes scanned the area quickly, instinctively checking for threats. The fire was still burning, the smoke rising into the night sky, but what really caught his attention was Mydei.

Mydei sat casually against a pillar, his eyes closed, his posture relaxed but purposeful. He had been waiting for them, of course. Phainon had expected nothing less. But there was something in the way Mydei rested that made it clear he was exhausted. Despite that, the way he carried himself still radiated strength, an unshakable calm that Phainon had always admired—and sometimes worried about.

Ermis came to a hesitant stop next to Phainon as they both reached the fire. Phainon couldn't help but notice the way Ermis looked at Mydei, eyes wide and full of fear, his posture stiff. The realization of what had just happened had finally sunk in for him, and Phainon could see it in every movement, every breath Ermis took.

Mydei opened his eyes as they approached, regarding Ermis with an expression that was far too calm for someone who had just been bleeding out hours ago. The exhaustion in his face was evident, but the sharpness in his gaze never wavered.

“Was it worth it?” Mydei’s voice cut through the stillness, surprisingly calm. But there was a fatigue to his words, the weight of everything that had transpired evident in the way he spoke.

Phainon glanced at Ermis, his eyes sharp and unwavering. It wasn’t a look that Mydei would have noticed, but it was one that made Ermis stiffen. The words Phainon didn’t speak were clear enough: *Next time, it won’t be Mydei bleeding out on the ground. It’ll be you*. It wasn’t a threat—just an undeniable truth, one that Ermis could sense, even if he wouldn’t admit it aloud.

Phainon’s eyes lingered on Ermis for a second longer, watching as the runaway seemed to shrink under the weight of that gaze. He didn’t care if Ermis understood or not, but Phainon had made his point.

Mydei sighed, breaking the silence that had settled between them. His gaze shifted to the Dromas, already tethered and ready to go, a subtle indication that the journey wasn’t over.

“The Dromas are ready,” Mydei said, his voice no longer holding any of the tension it had earlier. His earlier words seemed almost detached, as if he had already moved past the mess they had just cleaned up. “We can go.”

Phainon watched Mydei as he stood, his movements fluid despite the exhaustion. There was something in the way Mydei carried himself that made Phainon’s chest tighten. Even after everything, he was still unbroken, still the same. And yet, Phainon couldn’t help but wonder how long that would last.

His attention shifted back to Ermis, who was now standing awkwardly, avoiding Mydei’s gaze. He could see the guilt written all over the young man’s face. Phainon was certain Ermis would never make the same mistake again, but that didn’t erase what had happened.

Mydei’s voice brought him back to the present.

“Let’s get going,” he said again, this time more insistent, though still lacking any real emotion. “There’s no more time to waste.”

Phainon didn’t hesitate. With a subtle nod, he turned toward the Dromas, ready to leave the campsite behind and continue their journey. As he moved, his hand brushed against Mydei’s for just a second—only a brief contact, but it was enough to make Phainon’s heart race for a fraction of a second. He didn’t show it, of course, but something about the way Mydei stood next to him, unscathed and still unbroken, made it impossible to ignore the fierce protectiveness Phainon felt.

It was only when they began to mount the Dromas that Phainon allowed himself a deep breath, letting the tension slip away, even if just for a moment. They still had a long way to go. But as long as Mydei was with him, Phainon would face whatever came next, whatever it took to keep him safe.

With the reins in hand and the road ahead, Phainon’s eyes locked onto the horizon. It was never just about the mission. It was about keeping the ones you cared about safe. And Phainon wasn’t about to let anyone stand in the way of that.

The Dromas moved steadily beneath them, the rhythmic movement of the creature’s stride grounding Phainon. The air was cool, the weight of the journey settling in around them. But despite the fatigue that tugged at his limbs, Phainon didn’t let his focus waver. His gaze remained forward, watching for any sign of trouble, as his mind ran over the events of the day.

Then, out of the quiet, a soft voice broke the silence.

“Thank you.”

The words were barely audible, a simple sentiment, but one that held weight, especially coming from Mydei. It wasn’t something Mydei said often—if ever—but the exhaustion in his voice made the gratitude seem

genuine. Phainon's heart softened, but he didn't acknowledge it right away, not wanting to interrupt the rare moment.

Mydei's head, heavy with the day's toll, leaned against Phainon's shoulder. He didn't fight the urge to rest, to let his body relax against Phainon's warmth, as if in that moment, he could forget the bloodshed and chaos that had consumed their lives. It was a quiet surrender, a moment of peace.

Phainon's hand instinctively moved to Mydei's side, wrapping around his waist and pulling him closer. He didn't say anything—words seemed unnecessary. Instead, he simply guided him, his other hand gently rubbing soothing circles on Mydei's arm as they rode. The simple touch was grounding for both of them, a reassurance that they were in this together, that Phainon wouldn't let go.

For a long while, the two of them simply rode, the world around them fading into the quiet rhythm of their journey. Mydei's breathing slowed, and Phainon let his eyes flick briefly down to his companion, seeing the exhaustion etched in every line of his face. His thoughts drifted to the toll it had all taken—the constant battles, the sacrifices, the moments where they had both nearly lost everything.

Phainon couldn't help the flicker of guilt that crept up on him. He could have stopped Mydei from going in alone, could have insisted on going with him. But it was too late now. Instead, he leaned back slightly, letting Mydei rest in his arms, offering the only comfort he could.

The Dromas moved steadily forward, and Phainon's arm tightened just a fraction around Mydei's waist, drawing him closer as they continued on their journey. Mydei didn't stir, his head still nestled against Phainon's shoulder, trusting in the calm that Phainon provided. In this moment, with the road ahead and the world behind, Phainon allowed himself a brief moment of peace, his hand never leaving Mydei's side, the gentle circles offering a quiet promise in the silence of the night.

Whatever came next, they would face it together.

End Notes

Y’all how do u write this trope I literally can’t even back read this because of how it always skews from my vision of what the story AND trope was supposed to be😢😢

How do we feel abt these 3-4 things though? I’m gonna get to writing all of them eventually but which first?

One, toxic ex Mydei (U decide modern or canon divergence or sm else idgaf, I was listening to hate me and What a Shame, yes I had a gacha phase and got inspired by that)

Phantom of the Opera au or any musical you guys want me to write

War Trophy Phainon (Inspired by Mine Deliverer You’re Mine by Anon!) and or Flame Reaver Phainon (Maybe both??)

And yes how can I forget abt an incubi au? Decide if u guys just want smuts or a drawn out plot for that (And who should be the incubi?)

Or pathetic loser Phainon which Mydei lowkey feels guilty abt yelling to stfu, so fluffy.

I think I yapped enough abt that so uh, cast your votes and thank you for reading <333

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